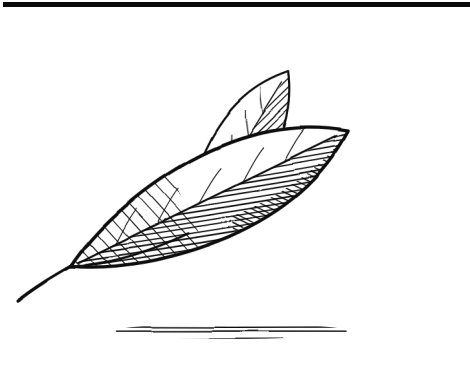


Bay leaf*Laurus nobilis*

Two dried leaves in the crew pot at the start, and keep them out of the freezer — dried beats fresh, and cold is what kills the oil.



Out of the bag: red stalk, wavy edge, a midrib you can feel.

IN THE MOUTH

FLAVOUR PROFILE

A cool, almost menthol lift first — eucalyptus and camphor — then a resinous middle of pine needle and dried grass, and a clove-like warmth that arrives late and stays. The leaf itself is bitter and drying, which is why it never reaches the plate; what it leaves in a pot is rounder than any of it — beans taste of more than beans. Fresh runs sharper and greener. Snap a good one and it cracks clean.

THE NUMBERS

0.6–1.5% Of the dry leaf is essential oil	26–63% Of that oil is 1,8-cineole, the eucalyptus note
41% Umbellulone in "California bay" — a different tree	90% Of the world's supply is wild-picked in Türkiye

THE COUSINS

True bay <i>Laurus nobilis</i>	Soft eucalyptus over a resinous middle, clove warmth that deepens on drying. The one you want.
Indian bay tej patta · <i>Cinnamomum tamala</i>	Clove and cassia, never eucalyptus — a true cinnamon relative. Not a substitute; a different spice.
"California bay" <i>Umbellularia californica</i>	Harsh camphor-menthol. 41% umbellulone, an irritant. Use a third of the leaf, or none.

WHAT TO DO WITH IT

USE	HOW, AND WHY IT WORKS
Laurel butter	250 g butter, six leaves cracked, 60 °C for 40 min, strain, roll, freeze. Fat is the solvent the oil wants.
Bay oil	200 ml olive oil, eight leaves, 60 °C for 30 min, cool overnight, strain. A week in the fridge.
Bay smoke	Dried branches on the embers, last minute, lid down. Cineole boils near 176 °C, so it rides the smoke.
Not the brine	Water takes almost none of the oil. Save the leaves for the roasting tin, under the joint.

Dose & storage. A dried leaf weighs 0.1–0.3 g. Two per 4 L crew pot, in at the start; one per litre of guest stock. Keep it airtight, dark, in the coolest locker — **never the freezer**. Ground leaf loses its oil fast: make bay salt small and often.

WHAT IT GOES WITH

TRADITIONAL Bay + white beans + olive oil + garlic. Forty minutes at a simmer is exactly the extraction a whole leaf needs, and the oil is the solvent.	MODERN Bay + brown butter + hazelnut + brown crab. Same roasted-nut chemistry as the crab's brown meat; the clove end sits under it.
COMPOUND Bay + cardamom + rice + cream. Cardamom is bay's chemical twin — about 34% 1,8-cineole, the same molecule.	FROM THE LITTORAL Bay + dried figs + red wine. The leaf that keeps the moth out of the fig is also its best partner — Turkish packers lay bay in the fig crates.

BUYING IT

Whole dried	Export grade, what Turkish packers call Hand Select: whole, colour intact, no insect marks, 2.5–10 cm. Olive-green, matte, wavy edge, red stalk. It should snap, not bend.
Fresh branches	Softer, greener, harsher. Use within the week or hang them to dry — drying makes it better, not worse.
Where it's from	Nine leaves in ten are hand-picked from Turkish maquis, whatever the jar says, and cross the border at about three dollars a kilo.
The clean way	Dried herbs are the one food class the EU lets be irradiated, to 10 kGy — but it must be labelled (Dir. 1999/2/EC art. 6). Buy from a market bin in a Turkish or Greek port, or a packer who states no treatment.

Hand it back if. Grey or brown, crumbling to dust, no smell when crushed — the oil has gone. And hand back any "bay" you cannot name: cherry laurel, *Prunus laurocerasus*, has a green stalk and a serrated edge, and is not food.

The name

Turkish *defne* keeps Daphne in it — the nymph who became the tree to escape Apollo, whose leaves he then wore. The Greeks put it on heads long before they put it in pots.

The turn

A relic of the subtropical laurel forests that ringed the Tethys Sea: its climate requirements have not shifted in three million years, which is why it grows wild on every warm, wet Mediterranean coast and sulks inland.

The blind spot

Fresh is not the better leaf, and freezing it to keep it fresh is the one move that wrecks it. Air-dried, bay carries *more* essential oil than the fresh leaf (Sellami et al. 2011).